CHAPTER TWENTY

LANDING THE ROAR

Targeting the Marquees

When Ratan heard from his friend Lord Kumar Bhattacharyya that Ford was looking for a suitable buyer for its luxury brands Jaguar and Land Rover, he was excited. For a self-confessed car aficionado, the temptation was irresistible. Krishna Kumar was consulted and he supported the move. Having sensed Ratan's desire to explore the possibility of buying the marquee brands, Bhattacharya arranged a confidential trip for him to the UK in 2007. Former Tata Motors MD Ravi Kant comments that during the visit, Ratan was impressed with what he saw.

Both Jaguar and Land Rover have a history. Jaguar's story goes back to 1921 when friends William Lyons and William Walmsley of Blackpool, England, began building motorcycle sidecars. The Land Rover, on its part, traces its origin to Coventry, England, where in 1877, John Kemp Starley and William Sutton forged a partnership to form a company to produce Rover cycles. Their company later gained fame for being the world's second manufacturer of four-wheel drive vehicles, after the Willys Jeep. But it was the larger Land Rovers—first designed in 1947—that excited adventurous off-roaders. Eventually, both Jaguar and Land Rover became quintessential British companies manufacturing luxury vehicles.

As the *Los Angeles Times* said, 'There have been Lotuses and Triumphs, Aston Martins and MGs, but no vehicle has epitomized the once-legendary British motor industry like that most English of cars, the powerful, sultry Jaguar.' It became the choice of the elite, an 'aspirational product'. As Peter Cooke, a professor of automotive management, says: 'In the UK market, you don't want to see your hairdresser driving a Jaguar.'